

ATTACKING SKILLS

The attacking team is the one in possession of the ball and which moves towards the opponent's goal. The players aim to pass the ball to each other and create a goal-scoring opportunity. They have to work together and try to avoid the opposing team. Here are some of the key ball skills attacking players need.



SHOOTING

If a player is in a position to score a goal, he or she will shoot. He or she can use the inside or outside of the foot, but the top (instep) will produce the hardest shot.

CROSSING

A pass from the edge of the pitch to the centre is called a cross. A cross into the penalty area is hard to defend and can often lead to a goal.

HEADING

Heading the ball can be an attacking or defensive skill. Heading the ball with the middle of the forehead gives maximum power and control, and avoids injury.

DRIBBLING

Running with the ball at the feet is known as dribbling. It is a vital skill required to beat an opponent.



OVERHEAD KICK

This is a really impressive way to score a goal. However, it is also a very difficult skill to master. A player has his or her back to the goal and must time the kick perfectly. It is best to practise this kick on soft ground to prevent injury.



1 LIFT OFF

Raise your non-kicking leg in the air and push off with the other foot.

2 SCISSOR MOTION

As you start to fall backwards, bring your kicking leg up. Your other leg should fall back to the ground.

3 STRIKE THE BALL

When your back is parallel to the ground, strike the back of the ball with the top of your foot.

DEFENDING SKILLS

The team without the ball must do everything it can to stop its opponent from scoring a goal. Here are some of the skills a team may use to regain possession of the ball or prevent the other team from scoring a goal. Once the defending team has won the ball, it becomes the attacking team.



TACKLING

A defender can use his or her feet to take the ball away from the attacker. Known as a tackle, timing is very important. If the defender kicks the player instead of the ball, it is a foul.

MARKING

By staying close to his or her opponent, a defender might be able to prevent the attacking team making a pass or even intercept the ball. This is known as marking.

INTERCEPTION

By marking a player closely or guessing where an attacker is going to pass the ball, a defender may intercept it. He or she can then start an attack for their own team.

GOALKEEPING

The goalkeeper is the last line of defence. He or she can use any part of the body to prevent a goal. Goalkeepers need to be strong, agile, and able to react quickly when the ball is struck at them.

DEAD-BALL SKILLS

Corners, throw-ins, free kicks, and penalties are all dead-ball situations known as "set-pieces". Teams will spend a lot of time practising set-pieces as they are good goal-scoring opportunities.



CORNER

If a defender kicks the ball over the goal line, the attacking team is awarded a corner. It is taken from the nearest corner arc.

THROW-IN

When the ball crosses the touchline, whichever team kicked the ball last loses possession. The other team can then throw the ball and begin an attack.

FREE KICK

If a player commits a foul outside the penalty area, the other team will be awarded a free kick. The closer this kick is to the goal, the greater chance the attacking team has of scoring.

PENALTY

If a player from the defending team commits a foul inside the penalty area, the attacking team is awarded a penalty – a one-on-one shot against the goalkeeper.

PENALTIES

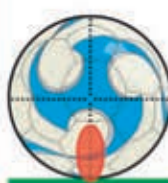
Here are the best places to aim for if you want to score a penalty, and the different ways you could strike the ball. Even if the goalkeeper guesses where you will shoot, he or she is unlikely to be able to save it – unless the shot is weak.

WHERE TO AIM YOUR PENALTY

- Goalkeeper is likely to save, unless he or she dives too early.
- Goalkeeper may be able to save if shot struck weakly.
- Goalkeeper is highly unlikely to save.



HOW TO STRIKE THE BALL



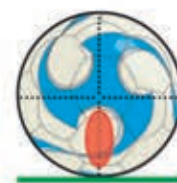
PASS THE BALL

This type of penalty is best for accuracy. However, striking the ball in this manner could produce a weak shot that the goalkeeper could easily save.



CHIP THE BALL

Only a confident player should try this shot, which is aimed up and over the goalkeeper. This shot also requires great skill to get it on target.



POWER SHOT

A powerfully struck penalty will always beat the goalkeeper – if it is on target. However, increased power also means less accuracy.